The Breyer Center for Overseas Studies in Florence
Bing Overseas Studies Program
Stanford University

Instructor: Ali Karamustafa
Class Schedule: Thursdays 3:30 – 6:20 p.m.
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OSPFLOR 35F

Migrants, radicals, and dictators: Italy & the Middle East in the modern era



In this class we explore Italy's long-standing, intimate, and often contradictory ties to the Middle East. We spend two weeks studying the broader Mediterranean context of Italian history, before entering the modern period by covering the unification of Italy in the nineteenth century. The early part of the course examines the role played by North African countries and the Ottoman Empire in the creation of modern Italy, offering an overview of Italy's (mainly abortive) colonial ventures, and studying the role of imperialism in the rise of Italian fascism in the 1920s. We then examine the region during the Cold War, devoting particular attention to the economic and political alliances which grew between Italy and Middle Eastern countries during this time. We will see how the former frequently sought to balance its own economic interests with the political aims of its allies in the Western Bloc. The final weeks of the course shift the focus to the contemporary period by taking up issues of immigration, geopolitical conflicts in the Mediterranean, and minority communities in Italy today.

During the course, we will be engaged in an ongoing discussion regarding the benefits and drawbacks of the notions of "Europe" and "the Middle East" in relation to Italy. How can we productively use these terms given their historical and political connotations, and what can Italy's relations with its Middle Eastern neighbors teach us about these simplistic geopolitical categories?

Learning outcomes

The main objective of this course is to challenge the notion of the Mediterranean as a region irrevocably divided between the Christian West and the Islamic Middle East. The course questions the usefulness of these categories as units of analysis and offers alternatives to prevalent notions of region and civilization. The course also seeks to understand the dynamics of modern geopolitics in historical perspective. Methodologically, students taking this course will learn how to carry out close readings of primary historical sources in order to construct arguments about the past and relate them to the presentday.

Ways of Learning
>Exploring Difference and Powers (EDP) >Social Inquiry (SI)

Assignments and Evaluation

Participation – 20%
Attendance is mandatory. Students should come to class prepared to discuss the readings.

Map quizzes – 15%
We will have three in-class map quizzes (see course schedule). Geography matters, folks!

Leading discussion – 15%
Each student, either alone or with a partner, will launch class discussion on one day during the quarter. You must come prepared to make *brief* introductory comments summarizing one of the readings for that day and to pose three well-formulated questions to the class.

Imaginging the Past: Interview/Diary Entry – 20%
Imagine and convey the worldview of a historical figure. You may choose one of two formats: interview or diary entry. For the interview, be sure that your interviewer does not ask anachronistic questions by imposing modern-day morals onto the past. You should imagine that the conversation is taking place in the past, and not the present. For the diary entry, you may narrate an ordinary day in the life of this person or else a particularly important historical moment from their lives. You should touch on themes we tackle in class, and bring in contextual knowledge about the area you are discussing.

Final paper – 30%
1,500+ words. Compare two primary sources we have analysed over the course of the quarter in order to show either changes or continuities in Italy's relationship to the Middle East. The comparison might also reveal that the contradictions or inconsistencies of the notion of the "Middle East" of Europe. Your paper should address the basic problems of reading primary sources: the audience, the motives and biases of the author, and the context in which the sources were written.

Course schedule and readings

Week 1 Italy on the Muslim-Christian frontier	**Readings** ➢ Adam Silverstein, *Islamic History: A Very Short Introduction* (Skim ch 1). **Thematic questions** What is a frontier? What was the impact of the rise of Islam on world history, and on the Mediterranean region? What are some of the defining features of Mediterranean society, in both its Christian and Muslim-majority expressions?

Week 2 The making of the modern world: Piracy, slavery & global trade	**Readings** ➢ Molly Greene, "The Early Modern Mediterranean", *Companion to Mediterranean History*, 91-103. ➢ *Primary source*: Kritovoulos, *History of Mehmed the Conqueror* (1467) ➢ Listen to *Ottoman History Podcast* on piracy in Mediterranean: https://www.ottomanhistorypodcast.com/2020/01/pirates.html **Thematic questions** How did the role of the Mediterranean in global context shift during the early modern period? Who were the predominant political players in the region, how were the contours of Europe and the Middle East shaped during this period? How were piracy and slavery vectors of conflict and exchange during this period?

Week 3 The *Risorgimento* & Italian identity ***Med geographymap quiz**	**Readings** ➢ *Ways of the World: A brief global history* (eds. Strayer et al): "Atlantic Revolutions", "Industrial Revolution and Colonial Endeavors". ➢ Vanda Wilcox, "Imperialism and Irridentism in Liberal Italy", *The Italian Empire and the Great War* (2012), 18-40. ➢ *Primary sources*. **Thematic questions** What changes were portended by the rise of nationalism in the global context? What relation did this have to the Italian diaspora and to Italian communities in the Mediterranean living beyond Italy's new borders?

Week 4 The new century and Fascism's rise	**Readings** ➢ "What is Fascism?" from Patrick Zander, *The Rise of Fascism* (2016) ➢ Victoria de Grazia, *The Perfect Fascist* (2020), chapters 1 & 11 ➢ *Primary source*: Filippo Tommaso Marinetti, "The Futurist Manifesto," 1909. **Thematic questions** What was the relationship between Italian colonialism and Italian nationalism? How did Italy, as a middle power, attempt to frame its colonial exploits differently from those of the British and French Empires?

Week 5 Geography and race in Italy's Mediterranean empire	**Readings** ➢ Arielli, Nir. "Beyond 'Mare Nostrum'. Ambitions and Limitations in Fascist Italy's Middle Eastern Policy." *Geschichte Und Gesellschaft*, vol. 37, no. 3, 2011, pp. 385–407. ➢ *Primary source*: Luigi Federzoni, "Hegemony in the Mediterranean", *Foreign Affairs*, 1936. **Thematic questions** How did fascist Italy's colonial aspirations change in the 1930s? What was the prevailing economic and political logic of Italian colonialism? How were Middle Eastern countries and national movements changing during this time period?

Week 6 The American-style postwar order ***Med countries 1950 map quiz**	**Readings** ➢ Luciano Monzali, "The Middle East in Italian Foreign Policy", *Italy & the Middle East: Geopolitics, Dialogue & Power in the Cold War*, pp. 68-73. ➢ *Primary source*: 1950 Report to the US National Security Council: NSC-68. **Thematic questions** How did Italy's relationship with the Islamic Mediterranean change in the post-war period? What role did Cold War ideologies regarding the economy and the global order have in Italy's relations with Middle Eastern countries?

Week 7 Cold War currents; Oil, communism, and the collapse of the post-war order	**Readings** ➢ Luca Riccardi, "Italy's foreign policy and the Palestine question", in *Italy and the Middle East. Geopolitics, dialogue and power during the Cold War* (2021). ➢ *Primary source*: Mu'ammar Gaddafi, *excerpts from speech at Zuwara*, April 1973. **Thematic questions** What was the place of the Middle East and Italy in the global order, in particular in relation to NATO and the USSR?

***Imagining the Past* due.**

Week 8 Berlusconism, economic stagnation, & the War on Terror	**Readings** ➢ Paul Ginsborg, *Silvio Berlusconi: Television, Power, and Patrimony* excerpts. ➢ *Primary source*: Oriana Fallaci, *The Rage and the Pride* (2002). **Thematic questions** What did the end of the Cold War portend for Italy's relations with its Muslim neighbors? How were these changes affected by new global economic conditions?

Week 9 The New Right, anti-immigration and Muslims in Italy ***Italian regions map quiz***	**Readings** ➢ Asher Colombo, Gianpiero Dalla-Zuanna, "Immigration Italian Style, 1977-2018," Population and Development Review, Vol.45 (2019): 585-615. ➢ Giorgia Meloni, Speech at CPAC, 2022. **Thematic questions** Describe the rise of "Lega Nord" in its political and economic context. What role did immigration play in its ideology, and how did this shift in recent years to become a mainstream question in Italian politics?

Week 10 Contemporary questions: trade & geopolitics	**Readings** ➢ Michael Tanchum, "The Geopolitics of the Eastern Mediterranean Crisis: A Regional System Perspective on the Mediterranean's new Great Game," published by Konrad Adenauer Stiftung (2020). ➢ Brighi, Elisabetta, and Marta Musso. "Italy in the Middle East and the Mediterranean: Evolving Relations with Egypt and Libya." *Italian Politics*, vol. 32, 2017, pp. 70–89. *JSTOR*, https://www.jstor.org/stable/26590047. **Thematic questions** What is Italy's current role in Middle Eastern geopolitics? What is the role of Italy's Muslim community in the country's economy and politics today?